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Sri Lanka Travel News



Lanka TOURGUIDE

Embracing a Sustainable Future

GOVERNMENT PLANS TO MAKE COLOMBO A VIBRANT CITY FOR ENTERTAINMENT

Cover Photo – Upcoming Port City Colombo

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Dawn of a Magazine for Sustainable Tourism

Welcome to the inaugural edition of Sri Lanka unfolded tour magazine 'The Lanka TOURGUIDE'. Born from the heart of our island's vibrant landscapes, resilient communities, and untold stories waiting to be shared.

Today's tourism is not just about destinations—it's about transformation. It's about embracing sustainable practices that protect our ecosystems, championing climate-responsive initiatives that future-proof our experiences, and nurturing community-led activities that empower the very people who make our journeys meaningful.

From the misty hills of agri-ecotourism to the rhythmic hands of craft artisans, Sri Lanka offers a tapestry of experiences that are as enriching as they are responsible. But to truly thrive, we must also embrace the digital frontier—leveraging platform marketing and smart technologies to connect, amplify, and innovate.

We urge our readers to keep a learning eye—curious, open, and ready to evolve. Tourism success must be measured not only in financial returns, but in cultural preservation, environmental stewardship, and social inclusion. Most importantly, we believe in the power of women and youth to lead this movement. Their creativity, courage, and entrepreneurial spirit are the heartbeat of rural revitalization. Let us walk beside them, support their ventures, and celebrate their leadership.

Together, let's reimagine tourism—not as an industry, but as a force for good. Let's make Sri Lanka a beacon of sustainable travel for the world to follow.

Samantha Pathirathna (PhD)

Chairperson/Managing Director
Lead Consultant
PASS Asian (Pvt) Ltd
ECO Treats Tourism (Pvt) Ltd.

BUILDING TRUST THROUGH COMMUNICATIONS

STARMEDIA Event Solutions (a subsidiary of Star Productions BTL Pte. Ltd.) is the managing body of Sri Lanka's International News Agency while operating as a PR AGENCY that partners with organizations to evolve promote and develop their activities through mass communication particularly through media platforms. We are a strategic communications agency with fast-moving intersection of multimedia, social media, electronic media and print media. We are ready to handle dynamic cost effective PR campaigns for any private / public Organisation who intends to cater to local and global audiences. We believe that our efficient efforts and innovative ideas will effectively reach the goals of our clients.

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FEEL AN AMAZING EXPERIENCE AT IMMERSIVE 7DEGREE IN COLOMBO

- Anusha Maureen

Immerse is a fully immersive experience, so expect to be "transported to a different world" through the advanced technology used. For a unique, immersive dining experience in Colombo, visit Immerse by 7 Degrees Restaurant, Sri Lanka's first such venue, which uses projectors, sensors, and Dolby Atmos sound to create a multi-sensory culinary journey for a small group. This fine-dining experience is designed by the renowned hospitality expert Nalin Malwenne, Managing Director of H.O.T. Travels.

Executive Chef Patrick Velans offers a captivating blend of technology and gourmet cuisine, with themes that change to transport diners to different worlds.

You can expect a unique experience at Immerse, with a multi-sensory journey. Immerse goes beyond typical dining by engaging all your senses through visual, auditory, and olfactory elements.

The high-tech advanced technology provides the space equipped with projectors, sensors, and a Dolby Atmos sound system to create dynamic environments. You can also enjoy themed experiences with multi-course menu curated to fit a changing theme for the evening, with each dish presented alongside its own audio-visual display to enhance the experience.

The restaurant will accommodate a limited number of guests, making it a unique and exclusive experience. If you wish to experience this exceptional opportunity make a reservation any day of the week by calling +94 112 559 222. 7Dedree Immerse is located at No.270, Park Road, Colombo 05.

Considerations for a First-Time Experience, given its unique nature and limited capacity, booking your spot in advance is much better.

Communicate Your Occasion:

If you're planning a special event, such as a proposal, note that the restaurant can play your own photos and videos upon request.



Launching

Print & Online Magazine

September – World Tourism Month



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Lanka Alliance of Tourism Journalists



Federation of Sustainable Tourism
Let's make Sri Lanka a sustainable destination



A New Dawn for Sri Lanka Tourism

This editorial launches 'Lanka TOURGUIDE', Sri Lanka's new sustainable tourism magazine, aiming to redefine travel in the island nation by promoting responsible practices that benefit local communities, protect natural and cultural heritage, and foster genuine connections with Sri Lanka's vibrant soul. By showcasing ecotourism, community-based initiatives, and the unique value of the nation's natural beauty and warm hospitality, the magazine seeks to inspire both travelers and industry stakeholders to embrace a future of sustainable growth that respects the land and its people, moving beyond traditional mass tourism models towards a more resilient and enriching experience for all.

Embracing a Sustainable Future

Welcome to Lanka TOURGUIDE, your guide to a Sri Lanka that breathes with nature, thrives through community, and flourishes through responsible travel. As a nation blessed with breathtaking landscapes and a rich cultural tapestry, Sri Lanka stands at a pivotal moment in redefining its tourism industry. We are launching this magazine to champion a vision of sustainable tourism, one that moves beyond traditional metrics of visitor numbers and revenue to focus on holistic well-being for our environment, our people, and our future.

Beyond the Horizon: A Commitment to Sustainability

In a world increasingly aware of its ecological footprint, Sri Lanka's unparalleled natural beauty—from its azure beaches and lush tea plantations to its national parks and misty mountains—becomes an even greater responsibility to protect. The TOURGUIDE will illuminate the path to a resilient tourism sector by showcasing initiatives that balance economic growth with environmental conservation. We believe that by minimizing negative impacts and maximizing contributions to biodiversity management, tourism can become a powerful force for preservation and restoration.

Empowering Communities: The Heart of Responsible Travel

True sustainability is rooted in the prosperity and empowerment of local communities. This magazine will highlight the stories of small and medium-sized businesses (MSMEs), local artisans, and community-led tourism projects that are integral to Sri Lanka's unique charm. We will explore how sustainable tourism can create meaningful employment opportunities, particularly for the nation's youth, and foster authentic connections between visitors and the people whose lives are enriched by their presence.

Celebrating Sri Lanka's Unique Soul

Sri Lanka's identity is built on more than just its stunning attractions. It is defined by the warmth of its hospitality, its unparalleled cultural capital, and the genuine spirit of its people. The Emerald Isle will celebrate these vital pillars of the tourism industry, demonstrating that a sustainable model does not diminish the visitor experience but deepens it, transforming a simple holiday into a profound journey of discovery and connection.

Join Us on This Journey

As The TOURGUIDE begins its journey, we invite you, our readers, to embark on a new era of travel with us. Let us explore the wonders of this beautiful island responsibly, supporting initiatives that nurture its natural treasures and uplift its people. Together, we can ensure that Sri Lanka's future as a destination is not just vibrant, but also enduringly sustainable and deeply fulfilling.

- Chief Editor

Government plans to make Colombo a Vibrant city, for Entertainment and Music in Asia



Brown Boy Pvt Ltd aims to create a global entertainment circuit based in Sri Lanka, connecting South Asia and putting the country on the global entertainment map



The tourism industry of Sri Lanka has recently announced its plans to create Colombo an excitement & vibrant city under "City Tourism" strategy by promoting Colombo as a tourism hub in South Asia. With this strategy, they aim to develop and enable Colombo to be able host international events of high standards. Tourism Deputy Minister Prof. Ruwan Ranasinghe said that Sri Lanka Tourism is ready to host a number of such events, in the year round event calendar. "We have some plans to hold world class events making a note that we continuously had Esala Perahera in Kandy as a mega event to attract foreign tourists but now we keep on adding more to the list with international events held in Colombo to promote Sri Lanka as a destination for major international music concerts. He emphasised that events like Entertainment & music is a huge industry and cities like Saul, Louisiana and countries like South Korea and India are booming their economy by capturing this opportunity. "Sri Lanka is bouncing back in terms of economy. These initiatives will reawaken Sri Lanka with an aim to boost the country's entertainment industry and place Sri Lanka on the world music and entertainment industry".

Reggae legend Alpha Blondy performed his first-ever concert in Sri Lanka on July 19, (2025), at the Colombo Air Force Grounds. Blondy was accompanied by his iconic band, The Solar System. The groundbreaking event was organized by Big Blast Events with EarGear Productions and YES101. The hospitality partner was Cinnamon Grand Colombo. The concert was a major cultural event for Sri Lanka, bringing the "Bob Marley of Africa" to the island for a night of reggae music and unity.

Colombo now prepares for a night of unforgettable music, dance, and celebration as Ne-Yo performs live in Asia for the very first time. Sri Lanka is set to make music history as global rhythm & blues (R&B) sensation Ne-Yo, a three-time Grammy Award

winner and renowned singer, takes the stage in Colombo for the first time. The mega show is scheduled for December 28,(2025) at the Sugathadasa Outdoor Stadium, an electrifying concert that will experience promises to close the year on the highest of notes. It will be an absolutely a world-class stage production, an open-air setting, and a night of unforgettable hits according Brown Boy Presents the event organisers.

Brown Boy Presents Co-Founder & CEO Amith Boteju commenting on the upcoming show, said: "Bringing Ne-Yo to Colombo is not just about hosting a concert; it's about creating a historic moment for Sri Lanka. Our mission has always been to put the island on the international entertainment map, and this event is a significant milestone in that journey." He said it's in their agenda to bring more and more entertainment events to the country. Boteju who lives in USA assured that he will fully support to make this mission a success and that he would directly negotiate with American and other artists to perform in Colombo.

This event is held with the support of Cinnamon Grand Colombo, Mastercard, Scope Cinemas, Emerging Media, Pickme, Wijeya Newspapers, and Artiste Connection, all working together to bring Colombo a night to remember. "As the countdown begins, excitement is already mounting. On December 28, Colombo will be closer than ever to one of the greatest voices in R&B" said Boteju. The prominent Reggae artist Alpha Blondy brought reggae and Ne-Yo brings the R&B culture, and likewise the world of music industry is now coming to Colombo.

Prof. Ruwan Ranasinghe Deputy Minister of Tourism told that "It is a historic moment for Sri Lanka since world famous artists are now performing in Colombo which creates immense opportunity to boost tourism in Colombo"

Colombo will be a place of connecting people of the region



opportunities to boost tourism from the neighborhood. We have many challenges to attract tourists for Colombo and keeping them for couple of days in the city. Therefore we need such glamorous events to create happenings. Events like this will rewrite the brand image of Sri Lanka and will make a mammoth opportunity for us to send the message across the world that Sri Lanka is on the upswing and these kind of entertainment events are happening in Colombo”.

Speaking at the occasion Buddhika Hewawasam Chairman Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) and Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau (SLTPB) told the media that “Sri Lanka tourism is aiming to make Colombo an exciting and vibrant city and to be a hub for entertainment and music in Asia. We are doing the groundwork to open it to the world. We initially invite our immediate neighbors like India, to our northwest, and the Maldives, to our southwest”.

He revealed that all the infrastructure has been built. Hotels are ready and the city is in the actual presence to welcome all levels of tourists from the luxury high end to the downwards.

Colombo City has a spirit of music, experience of entertainment. So we need crowds to come to Colombo exactly for the purpose of visiting Colombo. There are exciting sporting events happening in Sri Lanka like T20 and various other events including weddings and MICE events. These are coming-up and Music is a bigger part to align with it”.

He further indicated that Ne-Yo the world class artist, the icon is not only coming to Sri Lanka but he is coming to Asia for the first time and begins his performance tour from Colombo. Hewawasam noted capturing from the same own words of Ne-Yo that “Connecting people from music is one part of the game”. NE-YO having said that, Hewawasam highlighted that Colombo will be a place of connecting people of the region. He thanked both the Ministry of Tourism and Ministry of Sports for supporting to implement these ventures as we want to uplift Colombo as an entertainment city.

Hewawasam pinned that the whole aim is that Music entertainment is to be offered to the world from Colombo.

Kamal Munasinghe COO of Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts told that Cinnamon Colombo Hotels will always like to partner with this kind of



[PHOTO - The Show committee attended for Press Conference at Cinnamon Grand]

entertainment events which will help us to promote Colombo as a destination and also promote Sri Lanka as a brand in the global map of tourism. He urged his fullest support to make Colombo a Vibrant destination to be full of energy, enthusiasm, activity, and life.

Colombo

is the gateway to the wonder of Asia, with its rich colonial heritage, featuring a melting pot of races, religions and cultures. A city of contrasts. It is both an eclectic mix of shiny hotels and swanky office blocks, neighboring beautiful red-tiled colonial-era buildings. Sprawling bustling street markets brim with fragrant spices, colourful silks, cottons and fresh fruit and vegetables. Discover Colombo's multi-ethnic legacy with churches, mosques and temples congregating on the same streets, and delve into iconic sites including Fort Railway Station, the Red Mosque, and the Khan Clock Tower. Plunge into Colombo's enticing street food scene, eat like a local, and immerse yourself in the sights, sounds and aromas of the whirling Pettah Bazaar. This seaside city

offers a plethora of exciting adventures, experiences and places to visit. Delight in an exhilarating tuk tuk ride around the city, relish high tea at a magnificent colonial style hotel overlooking the azure ocean, and play a round of golf on scenic green courses. A shopper's paradise, exquisite boutiques feature international brands, and charming shops offer colourful local art and textured fabrics. The home of the famed Ceylon tea, delve into the vast array of fragrant flavoured teas, including banana and brandy. Featuring a fascinating heritage and enticing culture, Sri Lanka's capital is one of Asia's favoured travel destinations. Offering a vast selection of accommodation options, including rustic beachside shacks to lavish colonial mansions and stunning hotels, every taste and desire on where to stay is fulfilled. Discover the vibrancy of Colombo and explore a variety of fascinating attractions, as well as interacting with its authentic people. Delve into the city's cultural diversity as you traverse through the colourful streets of the lively market district Pettah, Colombo's most popular district. Sample delicious street food, choose of exotic



Floating Market Colombo

Sri Lanka

YOU'LL COME BACK FOR MORE

spices, meander through market stalls, and visit the Red Mosque. Spend time in the Fort area, Colombo's most significant commercial hub. Savor fiery street food with a perfect balance of flavour. Tempt your taste buds with Colombo's most delicious fast food Kottu Roti, comprising of finely chopped flatbread cooked on a hot skillet with vegetables, eggs and meat of your choice, this is scrumptious and a must-try. Enjoy a Colombo walking tour of the city's historic Fort and Pettah. Ride in a Tuk-tuk, off the beaten track in a three-wheeled chariot. Night Cycling City Tour: Riding through Colombo at night is an adventure and this unique addition to Colombo's nightlife scene is a welcome one and illuminated streets, beautifully lit-up monuments and a warm evening breeze lend the city an air of grace. Visit historical sites such as the Dutch Period Museum and the Dutch Reformed Church. Take the time to visit three Dutch Colonial-style buildings very close to the Colombo Fort. These include the Old Dutch Hospital, now a vibrant eating and shopping destination, the Dutch Period Museum, and the Wolfendhal Church which was what the Dutch sailors' first saw far off in the distance, when they arrived at the port. Recap your walk over iced cold beers at the Dutch Hospital Complex. This (thought) to be the oldest building in Colombo Fort area and this hospital dates back to the Dutch colonial era in Sri Lanka. Dutch Hospital now is a beautiful heritage building of thick walls and red-tiled roofs, is a contemporary shopping and dining mecca. Exuding an entertaining ambiance and exciting

atmosphere this precinct is the ideal place to unwind after exploring Colombo. Explore attractions including Galle Face Green, the famous Galle Road, which leads to the southern city of Galle along the south-west coast, is a neon pathway framed with shops and buildings, just a stone's throw away from the Indian Ocean. Spend time at the historical National Museum of Colombo, here among its shiny treasures is the grand golden throne of the King of Kandy, several ancient Buddhist artefacts and a priceless collection of rare palm-leaf manuscripts. This seaside promenade is the ideal spot to fly kites, blow bubbles, rendezvous, and frolic in the sea and delight in the beautiful views of the sparkling ocean. Challenge yourself with a round of golf at the distinguished Royal Colombo Golf Club. Play a round of golf at the Royal Colombo Golf Club, a tranquil spot in the heart of Colombo. City temples and Kovils; explore the holy Gangaramaya Temple. Delve into 19th century Gangaramaya Temple, one of the most significant places of worship in Colombo, featuring a mix of modern architecture and cultural essence, swirling with orange-robed monks revering radiant Buddha statues. A plethora of temple and Kovils dot the cityscape of Colombo, some essentials to visit include the new and old Kathiresan Kovil that features the annual chariot festival, and the Asokaramaya Buddhist Temple, adorned with spectacular grandeur. The finest murals cover the walls with intricate details and vibrant colours. Sri Ponnambalam Vanesar Kovil features a

mesmerizing architectural pattern and devotees gather here to pay homage to Lord Shiva. Shopping; In an effort to attract international visitors to Colombo, Sri Lanka, the government made some decisions that made it convenient for international luxury brands to enter the Sri Lankan market, thereby making shopping a key motivating factor for intra-regional travel. While keeping in mind that local brands also have to be protected, the government made an effort to make the international brands competitive in comparison to other cities in Asia.



Colombo

JOHN KEELLS A JOURNEY EXCEEDING 150 YEARS GROWING WITH THE NATION

John Keells Group the largest business conglomerate in Sri Lanka commemorates 155 years in business as at year 2025, growing with the nation of partnering country's growth and delivering exceptional value to their stakeholders.

Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts is its primary hotel brand, operating under John Keells Hotels (JKH) offering a diverse chain of properties in Sri Lanka and the Maldives. Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts brand was launched in 2005 is the luxury hospitality arm of John Keells Holdings PLC, comprising a diverse collection of hotels, resorts, and integrated developments in Sri Lanka and the Maldives, offering experiences from city luxury and beach resorts to nature-based retreats.

John Keells Group has been a trusted name and an integral part of the Sri Lankan economy through its innovation, good governance, professional management and strategic partnerships with the efficient leadership of Krishan Balendra as Chairperson-CEO of John Keells Holdings PLC. (His father Ken Balendra was also a former Chairman of JKH). Krishan is also the present Chairman of the Ceylon Chamber of Commerce and Ken was also formerly. It is the first time in The Ceylon Chamber's 186-year history where both father and son assumed the position of Chairmanship. Krishan is also the Hon. Consul General of the Republic of Poland in Sri Lanka and was a former Chair of the Employers Federation of Ceylon, Nations Trust Bank and the Colombo Stock Exchange. He joined JKH in 2002 with a law degree (LLB) from the University of London and an MBA from INSEAD.

The John Keells Group operates across seven industry sectors and is home to some of Sri Lanka's much-loved brands and provides careers to over 14,000 people in a respectful and inclusive workplace. Its commitment to their values are; integrity, trust, caring, excellence, and innovation, ensuring ethical and sustainable business practices, to project JKH as Sri Lanka's most respected entity. Cinnamon is an inspired hotelier presenting tradition with elegance across Sri Lanka and the Maldives. It is the Sri Lanka's largest hotel chain and specialize in nature and culture based destination travel. The warmth of Sri Lankan hospitality is always hand delivered

through their Cinnamon Colombo Hotels, Cinnamon Sri Lanka Resorts, Cinnamon Maldives Resorts, and South Asia's largest integrated resort - Cinnamon Life at City of Dreams. Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts represents a modern chain of hotels focused on vibrant hospitality, comfort, creativity, and a journey of discovery rooted in local culture and traditions.



Key Properties Include recently inaugurated Cinnamon Life City of Dreams, Cinnamon Grand Colombo, Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo, Cinnamon Red Colombo, Cinnamon Bentota Beach-Signature Selection, Cinnamon Lodge Habarana, Cinnamon, Cinnamon Bay Beruwela, Cinnamon Wild Yala, Cinnamon Citadel Kandy, Habarana Village by Cinnamon, Trinco Blu by Cinnamon, Hikka Tranz by Cinnamon, Kandy Myst by wala, and in the Maldives; Cinnamon Velifushi, Cinnamon Hakuraa Huraa, Cinnamon Dhonveli and Ellaidhoo Maldives by Cinnamon.



Krishan Balendra
Chairperson-CEO
John Keells Holdings

"Live with us to live the story of each destination we are present in across Sri Lanka and the Maldives. Discover a love for tropical island luxury with our hotels & resorts. Our deep roots to the natural and cultural heritage of every place we call home, is celebrated with you. What we believe in Inspiring moments, through personally celebrating what's important to you, in every destination that has celebrate the cuisine,



culture, and creativity of each our name. We are the heart of every destination we live in. We know the paths and waters that must be explored in every place we call home. We reside in. We empower and uplift the communities, we locale we share space with. We are a source of experience, education, entertainment, and enlightenment wherever we exist. We respect our lands, waters, wildlife, colleagues, and communities. This guides everything we do. We base over 35 humanitarian and conservation projects on the needs of the destinations we are present in. We are the leisure sector of Sri Lanka's largest listed conglomerate - John Keells Holdings PLC".

John Keells Holdings diversified into the tourism industry with the acquisition of Walkers Tours in 1972 and established its first hotel in Habarana in 1973. In 1980s Walker Tours renamed as Hotel Management & Marketing Services Limited. In 1981, they were managing seven resorts with 4 beach resorts on the

Southern Coast; Beach Hotel Bayroo (presently Cinnamon Bay Beruwela), Hotel Swanee Beruwala, Ceysands Hotel Bentota, and Ambalangoda Rest House. The other three resorts were in the countryside the Habarana Lodge, Habarana Village and Kandy Walk Inn, which was later renamed as Cinnamon Citadel Kandy. John Keells acquired Whittall Boustead and gained control of Bentota Beach Hotel and Coral Gardens Hotel (Presently Hikka Tranz by Cinnamon).

In 1990s, Hotel Management & Marketing Services Limited renamed as John Keells Hotels. In 1993, John Keells owned and managed 900 rooms which accounted for 16% of the room capacity of resorts located outside Colombo. John Keells ventured into the Maldives market in 1996 with the acquisition of the 80-roomed Velidhu Resort Hotel. John Keells hotel chain underwent a major restructuring in 2004. All resorts, including listed resorts and Maldivian resorts brought under one holding company, Keells Hotels Limited.

John Keells Hotels introduced the "Chaaya Hotels & Resorts" brand at ITB Berlin in 2007. The brand took its name from the Sanskrit word Chaaya meaning image. Habarana Village was the first resort to be re-launched under the new brand after refurbishment. Subsequently, other all other resorts were also re-launched under Chaaya brand. Finally the Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts brand was completed in 2015. Cinnamon Lodge Habarana was the first rebranded hotel of the John Keells Hotels.

- Claude Gunasekera

SRI LANKA TO ATTRACT HIGH SPENDING TOURISTS



Business Class Air Passengers

Sri Lanka's tourism sector is on the brink of significant growth driven by substantial investments and a strategic push to attract high-spending tourists over an effective strategic plan to be launched shortly. The tourism industry is poised for a major boost amid rising demand. Sri Lanka Tourism is actively enhancing its appeal to the high-end tourism market, aiming to attract a greater number of affluent travelers and boost a set revenue target of a record-breaking \$5 billion this year (2025).

require a strategic push towards improving overall service standards, travel experience, and an innovative line of product offerings and ensured that tourism's benefits extend beyond urban hubs to rural communities. The government aims to achieve an overall tourist arrivals of 3 million with a strategy promoting the island as a premier destination for discerning travelers highlighting the country's unique attractions and experiences to plea high-spending travelers. The country has a considerable

of rooms and value added offerings. Sri Lanka is to solidify its position as a leading travel destination, focusing our unique smile, hospitality and high-quality service. International social media buzz that high-end tourism in Sri Lanka is growing, with influencers and media personnel showcasing luxury experiences and destinations, contributing to a positive image and increased international interest in the island nation.

This digital marketing strategy has helped Sri Lanka to attract high-spending tourists and promote Sri Lanka as a top-tier destination. Certain attempts are being made by local social media platforms to sabotage the government through fake gossip, targeting to insult about tourism arrivals. In response to this; Deputy Tourism Minister Prof. Ruwan Ranasinghe told Daily News that "Sri Lanka should pursue a balanced tourism approach by attracting a mix of high-end, mid-range, and budget travelers, ensuring all segments in the country have opportunities to benefit from tourism revenue. This strategy involves diversifying tourism offerings and promoting sustainable practices to social benefits for all people in the country.

Prof. Ranasinghe is a proficient, having PhD in Tourism Management, BSc in Tourism and Hospitality Management

and as a Senior Lecturer at Uva Wellassa University, opined with his academic proficiency that High-end Tourism is not only focused on luxury accommodations, but it has to couple with delighting experiences. Mid-range tourists should be offered a mix of comfortable accommodations with Bed & Breakfast (B&B) options, engagement in activities, also with some luxurious experiences and access to diverse attractions like wildlife parks, cultural sites, and



Tourism Minister Vijitha Herath

Tourism Minister Vijitha Herath stressed the need for a balanced approach that prioritizes both quality and quantity of tourist arrivals. He said Sri Lanka is focusing on enhancing the quality of its tourism offerings in order to strive for high-end travellers and

number of rooms suitable for high-end tourists while developing new accommodations. The hotels in operation at present are experiencing increased occupancy, indicating a demand. Further emphasis is also being placed on enhancing the quality



Prof. Ruwan Ranasinghe
Deputy Tourism Minister

historic locations. They seriously consider 'value for money' and may largely depend on online tourism reviews. "We have to cater to Budget Tourists such as backpackers or low-cost travelers for friendly Home Stay Accommodations (HAS), affordable transportation options, and budget-

The Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) is releasing approximately 3,000 acres of government land for tourism investments with immediate effect. This initiative aims to attract both domestic and international investors and boost the tourism sector with an estimated \$50-60 million in investments. The SLTDA has launched a digital platform, the "Land Bank Management Information System (LBMIS)," to facilitate the process. Lands will be offered on a 33-year lease. These lands are located in strategic areas, including Bentota, Kalpitiya, Pasikudah, Trincomalee and few other areas including north. SLTDA is actively promoting investment opportunities and is committed to a transparent process for allocating land to investors, according to Buddhika Hewawasam Chairman SLTDA/SLTPB (Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau).

SLTDA former Chairman Priantha Fernando said in August last year that SLTDA received 39 project proposals for hotels worth \$ 55 million investment, with 16 approved worth \$ 26 million. He said lands were identified in Kalpitiya, Kuchchaveli, Bentota, Delft Islands, and Mannar for private sector development.

"Sri Lanka has the assets to be one of the most desired destinations in the world. What we need now is scale, innovation, and consistency. Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts is at the forefront of showcasing this potential, offering luxury, lifestyle, and authentic experiences that appeal to travellers globally. We harness technology and innovation to deliver seamless, personalized guest experiences, while ensuring sustainability and inclusivity remain at the heart of our growth," said Hishan Singhawansa, CEO of Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts. He said "Recently launched Cinnamon Life is a landmark of US\$1.2 billion integrated resort in Colombo, and the largest development of its kind in South Asia, with 687 rooms, over 160,000 sq. ft. of MICE facilities for up to 5,000 guests, and a mix of dining, and entertainment, residences, retail etc. Kamal Munasinghe Chief Operating Officer, Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts said that "Cinnamon Grand, Cinnamon Lakeside and Cinnamon Red have increased occupancy rate to a considerably satisfied level. Sri Lanka was at ground zero level during the economic crisis, but is now gradually building up to attract upmarket tourists. The tourism sector is now playing a pivotal role in

revitalizing the Sri Lankan economy, and the private sector is seriously contributing an extra effort to boost the tourism industry. Cinnamon Hotels are targeting high-end travelers through global sales offices in India, Japan, UK, China, and few other countries through their website brand.com and ongoing promotional events. Wide scale ground work has already begun through Cinnamon worldwide marketing offices and through global marketing network avowed attracting upmarket and business tourists.

Munasinghe said "Colombo will soon be developed to a popular tourist destination specially focused at high-end tourists with our impressive city attractions and the presence of deluxe upscale hotels located in the city" "Cinnamon hotels can cater to nearly 900 rooms in Colombo with different guest choices such as elegant, grand style, village atmosphere and homey private stays with sense of superior quality, lavishness, and exceptional offering hope for the future of tourism ensuring guests have a unique experience of the country" said Munasinghe.

He proposed that a joint efforts should be taken with the government to improve MICE (Meetings, Incentives, Conferences, and Exhibitions) business, foreign weddings sports tourism and focused on individual luxury travelers.

He also noted the industry faces challenges to reach 3 million arrivals due to limited airport capacity and air connectivity. Immediate actions should be taken to rectify such issues. He appreciated that some efforts have already been commenced by the government and requested the state tourism to engage aggressively in approaching high-end travelers linked with globally based diplomatic missions of Sri Lanka.

Hiran Cooray, Chairman Jetwing Hotels told that "Low-end tourist arrivals in Sri Lanka can negatively impact the country by potentially straining infrastructure, contributing to environmental damage, and fostering cultural commodification, while high-end tourists tend to spend more and are more likely to engage with local businesses and culture in a sustainable way. High-end tourists tend to spend more on accommodation, activities, dining, and shopping, leading to greater revenue for the local economy. They are more likely to engage with local businesses, including high-end hotels, restaurants, and tour operators, creating more opportunities for local employment and economic growth. He said low-end tourism has a tendency

for increased waste, litter, and possibility for pollution from budget accommodations such as home stay and certain activities that can negatively impact the environment. Cooray also noted about the Cultural Commodification and pointed out that low-end tourists can lead to the commercialization and simplification of local culture, potentially eroding its authenticity while their lower spending can lead to a smaller overall economic contribution compared to high-end tourists who spend more per day. He also noted that some low-end tourists can associate with illegal activities like drug use, prostitution, or exploitation of local resources. A pressing concern raised by Chandra Wickramasinghe, Chairman / Managing Director of Connaissance De Ceylan revealed there's a potential shortfall in accommodation for high-spending tourists due to the growing demand. The country has over 10,000 rooms suitable for high-end tourists. He cautioned that, without addressing the possible shortfall in accommodation for high-spending tourists, Sri Lanka may struggle to meet the demand from affluent travellers. Continued focus and strategic planning, Sri Lanka can harness its full potential as a premier destination for high-spending tourists, driving economic growth and enhancing its global tourism profile, Wickramasinghe opined.

"Tour operators play a crucial role in ensuring traveler safety and security, especially in destinations with safety concerns. They may also play a role in advocating for infrastructure improvements to support high-end tourism. While online travel agencies offer convenience, tour operators differentiate themselves by providing personalized service and expertise, which is particularly important for high-end travelers. By focusing on these key areas, tour operators can effectively attract high-end tourism, contributing to the growth and sustainability of the tourism sector in a destination"

stated Nalin Malwenna Managing Director, House of Travels & Tourism a tour operator engaged in high end travels particularly to the European market as local agent for PATA Germany.



Buddhika Hewawasam, SLTDA/SLTPB



Hiran Cooray Jetwing Hotels



Chandra Wickramasinghe Thema Collections



Nalin Malwenna HOT Tourism

Hilton Colombo & Hilton Residences, premier destinations for Business, Leisure, and Signature Events



EXPERIENCE HILTON HOSPITALITY

WHERE SUSTAINABILITY IS WOVEN INTO EVERY STAY

Hilton is weaving sustainability into every guest stay by reducing emissions and waste, conserving resources, promoting biodiversity, and sourcing responsibly. This includes using AI for food waste management, investing in sustainable building design, and tracking utility consumption globally via the LightStay system to drive improvements and create a positive impact on the environment and communities.

Hilton uses smart technology, LED lighting, and sustainable design to reduce energy consumption across its global portfolio. The company implements water-saving efforts in guest rooms and landscaping and has a Water Efficiency Playbook for owners. AI-driven waste sorting, in-house composting, and strategic food sourcing help prevent and divert food waste from landfills. Hilton also supports biodiversity and promotes responsible sourcing by partnering with local producers.

LightStay System tracks energy, water, waste, and emissions at all Hilton properties globally, providing data to inform further sustainability efforts. Artificial intelligence is used to manage food waste and improve building efficiency, while smart building management software monitors real-time energy usage. Hilton invests in sustainable design and construction practices to create more efficient properties. Some Hilton hotels offer refillable toiletries in bathrooms to reduce plastic waste. Guests can enjoy fruits and vegetables picked from local producers.

Claude Gunasekera

Hilton Sri Lanka is significantly expand its presence in the Sri Lankan hospitality industry to manage six Hilton Hotels & Resorts and DoubleTree by Hilton properties in key tourist locations in Sri Lanka. This expansion will broaden Hilton's portfolio beyond its existing Colombo hotels and resorts, introducing more properties for DoubleTree brand in Sri Lanka and strengthening its footprint in Asia Pacific by leveraging the country's growing tourism sector. Hilton with Melwa Hotels & Resorts is to operate more hotels to its portfolio, according to www.globaltravelerusa.com.

The deal included three Hilton Hotels & Resorts properties and three DoubleTree by Hilton properties, marking the debut of DoubleTree in Sri Lanka. Hilton's strong international brand image and successful operations in Sri Lanka provide a solid foundation for further growth and expansion. The new hotels were planned to strategically locate in destinations such as Yala, Kosgoda, Kandy, Nuwara-Eliya, Colombo International Airport, and Negombo. Yala has already begun operations. Hilton aimed to capitalize on Sri Lanka's burgeoning tourism growth by expanding into sought-after destinations and offering its renowned hospitality.

Hilton Colombo transforms to sustainability at the forefront using eco-friendly material, energy-efficient lighting, and water conservation systems and freshly renovated 263 rooms of its 368 revamping its outlook with major update of the property. Hilton setup a new benchmark for Sri Lankan hospitality as the first international five-star hotel and landmark property located in Colombo.



Manesh Fernando, Area General Manager at Hilton Sri Lanka, said

"Our newly refurbished rooms are a perfect blend of style, comfort, and smart functionality, designed for today's traveller. Hilton Colombo has been part of the city's heartbeat for almost forty years, and these upgrades ensure we remain the preferred choice for both local and international guests".

The new refurbished rooms across 9 categories, were each combining modern architecture with eco-friendly amenities and cutting-edge technology. Now all 368 rooms are well-appointed guest rooms and suites, including two Executive floors with exclusive lounge access. Design inspiration of the graceful unfolding of the lotus flower, is with interiors designed to capture natural light from day to night, creating a calm and harmonious retreat.

Over the last three decades Hilton has been hosting world leaders, dignitaries, celebrities,

and international conferences. Over 10,000 weddings hosted from intimate gatherings to grand banquets. Thousands of hospitality students trained at Hilton Colombo, many are now holding senior positions here and abroad. The Grand Ballroom is Colombo's first pillarless hall considered as the most sought-after wedding venue in the city, accommodating up to 900 guests. Hilton is a venue of choice for major conferences, high-profile launches, and cultural celebrations. Host of one of Sri Lanka's largest **Oktoberfest festivals**.

Hilton Colombo Residences

the 33-storeyed building is another property managed by Hilton. One of Colombo's premier hospitality destinations, offering a blend of comfort and convenience. Variety of stylish rooms, suites, and penthouses ideal for business travelers, families, and long-stay guests. Rooms and suites feature modern amenities, fully-equipped kitchens, laundry facilities, multimedia hubs, and options for smoking or non-smoking preferences. Renowned for its spacious suites and exceptional service, the property caters to both business and leisure travelers, providing an ideal environment for short visits, long stays and family getaways. As Colombo's only pet-friendly city hotel, Hilton Colombo Residences creates an inclusive and welcoming atmosphere, ensuring that every guest, including four-legged companions, feels at home. Guests enjoy modern facilities, personalized experiences and a warm ambiance that reflects Hilton's global reputation for excellence.

Hilton Colombo Residences is also a destination for food lovers, with dining experiences that bring together global flavours and local flair: FLOW: Sri Lanka's first restaurant with five live open kitchens, Basico Bar Lounge: A versatile café by day and stylish lounge by night. Level3 Poolside: An open-air venue next to the pool, serving light bites, refreshing drinks, and à la carte meals. Its resort-like feel, complete with loungers and umbrellas, makes it a favourite spot to relax during the day or enjoy Colombo's tropical evenings. The Sunday poolside brunch combines food, music, and atmosphere for a memorable city escape.

Hilton Colombo Residences offers versatile venues for conferences, weddings, and social events. Union Ballroom, Level 03: Versatile event space adjacent to the poolside, Conference Room for private events with natural daylight. All venues are equipped with modern audiovisual facilities and customizable layouts.

DoubleTree by Hilton Weerawila Rajawarna Resort, is located in the tranquil town of Weerawila, ideally positioned for both relaxation and adventure. Nestled on the banks of Lake Weerawila, it offers guests a serene natural setting with uninterrupted views of the water and abundant birdlife, including spoonbills, pelicans, and kingfishers. is a tranquil retreat nestled along the shores of Lake Weerawila, surrounded by lush greenery and vibrant birdlife.

The resort combines contemporary design with natural beauty, offering a balance of relaxation, adventure, and authentic Sri Lankan culture. Overlooking a lake that lies on a migratory bird route, the property is a paradise for bird enthusiasts, with spoonbills, pelicans, kingfishers, and herons frequently seen from balconies, the poolside, or while dining outdoors. Spacious accommodations, diverse dining, wellness facilities are ideal for families, couples, business travelers, and nature lovers seeking a lakeside sanctuary in southern Sri Lanka.

The resort Closer to Yala and Bundala National Parks. Resort features 78 well-appointed non-smoking rooms and suites, each designed with comfort and style in mind. Private balconies and terraces offer serene lake or garden views, while modern amenities include Wi-Fi, HDTVs, minibars, and 24-hour in-room dining. Accessible rooms ensure inclusivity, while the spacious Presidential Suite provides expansive interiors for indulgent stays. The resort boasts one of Sri Lanka's longest pools at 75 meters, offering uninterrupted views of Lake Weerawila. The Grand Rajawarna Ballroom hosts up to 600 guests in banquet style, making it a premier venue for weddings and corporate gatherings. The lakeside resort is surrounded by rich birdlife and nature, convenient gateway to Yala and Bundala National Parks, Spacious rooms, suites, and a Presidential Suite with private balconies, five diverse dining venues, including rooftop and swim-up pool bar experiences, 75-meter infinity pool overlooking Lake Weerawila, Grand Rajawarna Ballroom and versatile event spaces for large and intimate gatherings

Hilton Yala Resort is a unique retreat set at the edge of Sri Lanka's iconic Yala National Park, the park with the world's highest density of leopards. Spread across 7 acres, the resort blends seamlessly into its natural surroundings, offering guests the rare experience of staying in refined comfort while immersed in untamed nature. Its design celebrates both modern style and Sri Lankan heritage, with natural elements and open

spaces that frame sweeping views of the Indian Ocean and dense forest. Guests are surrounded by the beauty of nature, with the sights and sounds of Yala's wilderness ever present in the backdrop of their stay. The resort's central bio pond attracts a variety of bird species and reflects its commitment to eco-sustainability. Convenient chauffeured buggies help guests move comfortably around the property, while guided walks with expert rangers offer opportunities to connect with the environment at a more leisurely pace.

Blending nature, adventure, and personalized hospitality, Hilton Yala Resort is a haven where every moment reflects the spirit of Sri Lanka's wild south coast.

Hilton Yala Resort is situated between the jungle and the Indian Ocean, offering a striking backdrop for adventure and relaxation. Guests can explore nearby cultural and natural landmarks including Sithulpawwa Buddhist Monastery, National Parks, Kalametiya Bird Sanctuary, and the Amaduwa Fishing Village. The resort features 42 exclusive villas and suites, each designed to immerse guests.



Hilton Colombo Residences



DoubleTree by Hilton, Weerawila



Hilton Yala Resort

SRI LANKA GROUNDING FOR SATA ACCOLADES IN COLOMBO

The South Asian Travel Awards (SATA) is holding their 9th edition in Colombo Sri Lanka, from September 19-20, 2025, with a Gala Ceremony at the Cinnamon Grand Colombo, grounding its "big day" in the city. This annual event celebrates excellence in the South Asian travel and hospitality industry and has seen strong participation from various countries.

Suraj Khan (Left) and Ismail Hameed Chairman of SATA



Sri Lanka Tourism is grounding to host the 9th annual South Asian Tourism Awards (SATA) in Sri Lanka, from September 19-20, to honor the best in South Asian travel and hospitality. SATA serve as a platform that celebrates excellence while encouraging collaborating, innovating and to focus on sustainable tourism growth in the region's hospitality sector. The event aims to showcase the unique hospitality and tourism offerings of the South Asian region. The Cinnamon Grand Colombo, will host this gala ceremony this year in association with Sri Lanka Tourism.

SATA 2025 is proudly endorsed by leading tourism organisations across South Asia. Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau (SLTPB), The Hotels Association of Sri Lanka and The Sri Lanka Association of Inbound Tour Operators (SLAITO) are the key stakeholders of the event from Sri Lanka. The regional partners

are Visit Maldives Corporation Limited, (VMCL), Nepal Tourism Board (NTB), along with major national travel associations such as Travel Agents Association of India (TAAI), Indian Association of Tour Operators (IATO), Maldives Association of Travel Agents and Tour Operators (MATATO), Confederation of Accredited Tour Operators (CATO), Association of Travel Agents, Maldives ATA, The Hotels Association of Sri Lanka (THASL), Sri Lanka Association of Inbound Tour Operators (SLAITO), Hotel Association Nepal (HAN), Restaurant Association of Bhutan Bangladesh International Hotel Association (BIHA), Hotel and (HRAB), National Boating Association of Maldives (NBAM) and Association of Tourism Trade Organizations, India (ATTOI). SATA is further supported by a strong network of regional Hospitality Partners, including Mandarin Hotel (Sri Lanka), Sheraton Grand Bangalore at Brigade Gateway (India),



Buddhika Hewawasam.SLTDA

PHOTOS OF THE PRESS



Virosh Perera. Cinnamon

Andaz Delhi (India), Hulhulé Island Hotel (Maldives), Holiday Inn Express Kathmandu Naxal (Nepal), Zhiwaling Heritage (Bhutan), and Holiday Inn Dhaka City Centre (Bangladesh). Hotel (Maldives).

The Tourism enormous event - SATA brings over 300 delegates from across the South Asian region. South Asia's leading brands will participate from Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka with endorsement from national tourism organisations of each country along with various travel agents and hotel associations. SATA is a premier platform that celebrates performance excellence in the tourism regional evaluation process and will culminate in the awarding of various categories to recognized hospitality properties and service providers across the region.

Sri Lanka as host nation, will showcase their renowned hospitality, resilience, and commitment to advancing tourism on the global stage. SATA recognizes outstanding achievements and contributions in various categories, including hotels, resorts, and other tourism-related services. The awards involve a multi country evaluation process, assessing nominees from South Asian countries before the final gala ceremony.

This year's edition, will have a forum for thought leadership, strategic networking and cross-border unity which considers a unique initiative. The first day of SATA is scheduled for connected conversations providing opportunities for regional hotels and travel agents to connect and create business momentum. SATA Alliance Meeting, is also scheduled the same day to discuss ways and means to promote regional tourism. The meeting also aims to identify strategies for collaboration among regional tourism organizations and adopt a strategy to closely work together.

– Claude Gunasekera

Tourism Saga event, which brings together over 300 delegates from across South Asia to celebrate South Asian hospitality. The event aims to showcase the unique hospitality and tourism offerings of the region.

The islandchief
Monthly Travel Tabloid

TOURGUIDE
Sri Lanka Travel Guide
Embracing a Sustainable Future



were identified at a two day workshop held in Sigiriya last weekend. The programme focused on experience sharing, strategic planning, and collaborative action towards achieving this goal.

Senior tourism officers from all the nine provinces of the country attached to Provincial Councils and dedicated state tourism institutions attended the programme.

Malkanthi Rajapaksha Director General of SLTDA attending as the Chief Guest said at the gathering that in order to support the initiatives taken by provincial tourism officers SLTDA will work closely to identify and develop at least one sustainable destination in each province. She also noted that Sigiriya has been successfully recognized as Sri Lanka's first sustainable destination, awarded by world renowned Green Destinations Foundation, following two years of dedicated collaboration among key stakeholders under the sustainable Tourism Development Initiative.

Ms. Rajapaksha also emphasised that "we may face certain funding restriction when developing these destinations but SLTDA could liaise with some funding agencies to support them to some extent while we together should Work closely with a positive mindset to overcome such barriers".

"Developing a sustainable destination is not an easy task as merely developing a tourist attraction. A sustainable destination is a place that strives to protect and enhance its natural, cultural, and social resources while meeting the needs of visiting tourists and residents. In essence, it's about balancing tourism development with environmental conservation and community well-being" said Upali Rathnayake Deputy Director General / Head of Sustainable Tourism Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority.

Muditha Abeysinghe Manager Sustainable Tourism Unit SLTDA, Ramitha Wijethunga, National Project Coordinator UNDP, Mahinda Tennakoon President Hotels Association of Habarana, Ranjith Kumarasinghe Assistant General Manager L&D – Northern Cluster Heritage Kandalama were also among speakers at the workshop.



Malkanthi Rajapaksha Director General SLTDA



Upali Rathnayake DDG/SLTDA

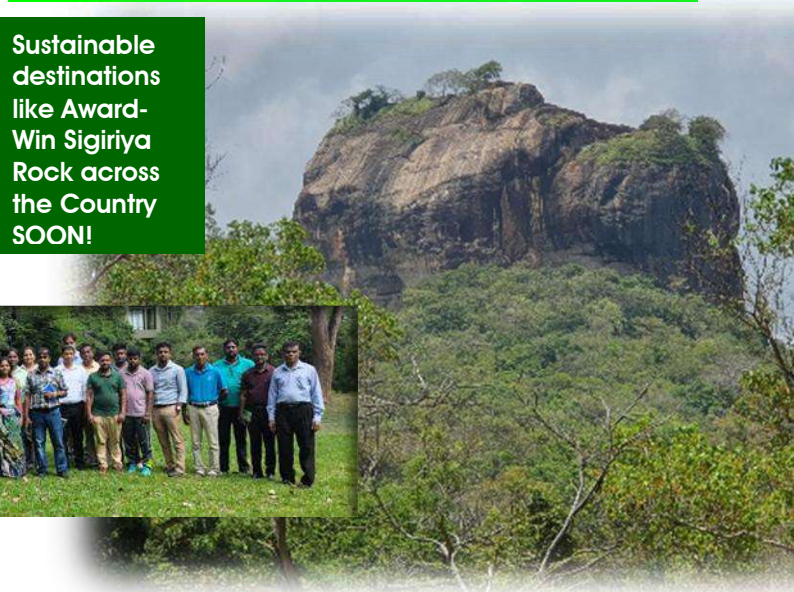
Workshop participants – State Officers from across Sri Lanka attached to Tourism



SL GOVT, PLANS TO DEVELOP SUSTAINABLE TOURISM DESTINATIONS ACROSS SRI LANKA

Sustainable destinations like Award-Win Sigiriya Rock across the Country SOON!

Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) took a bold decision to support developing tourist attractions in to sustainable tourist destinations throughout Sri Lanka. Some of the tourist destinations presented by the provincial officers were unexplored niche destinations. These destinations are both less-known and high appealing locations. These highly potential destinations





Tourism Deputy Minister accepts Patron & Head of Advisory Board SUSTOURISM-FST

Prof. Ruwan Ranasinghe, Deputy Minister of Tourism, accepted to be the Patron of the Lanka Federation of Sustainable Tourism, when Claude Gunasekera the Initiator of the Organisation proposed the offer at a ceremony held in Colombo.

He will be the Head of Advisory Board or act as the Chief Advisor to the Board although a Chairman is elected whereas he will lead the Advisor Committee.

Prof. Ranasinghe was offered the position based on a clause of the constitution of the Alliance that; 'The Sri Lanka Government's Minister, Deputy Minister or Secretary to the Ministry in charge of Tourism will be offered the honorary position of Patron by constitution.



Prof. D.A.C. Suranga Silva (Professor of Tourism Economics at the University of Colombo and Coordinator Sustainable Tourism Unit, Colombo University, Lead Trainer Global Sustainable Tourism Council (GSTC)., Dr. Samantha Pathirathna (Sustainable Tourism Expert at ADB, Business Master & Coach at Federation of Chamber of Commerce and Industry, Chairman/MD at Eco Treats Tourism), Chandra Wickramasinghe Founder, Chairman/Managing Director of Connaissance De Ceylan, Thema Collection. Prominent Eco-Friendly and Cultural Preservation DMC. Nalin Malwenna. Managing Director HOT Tourism, Tony Maheswaran. Director Strategic Planning, HOT Tourism. Kamal Munasinghe, Chief Operating Officer, Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts nominated Ms. Gayani Punchihewa. Director Rooms Division, Cinnamon Grand Colombo, Eksath Wijeratne, CEO, Browns Hotels & Resorts, Indaka De Silva, Chairman's Representative Barbeyrn Group Conrad Dissanayake, Managing Director, DGSM Travels, Ms. Anitha Munasinghe, Country Manager, Solidaridad, Chinthana Dumindahewa, Country Coordinator (Sri Lanka/Maldives) Green Destinations, Poornaka Delpachithra, Country General Manager / Director - Sri Lanka. Intrepid Travel, Gayan Abeykoon, Media Secretary to Deputy Minister of Tourism, Mahes Bandara, CEO Haritha TV. (Television channel focussed on Nature, Heritage, Local Culture, Folk Arts and Agriculture. Muditha Abeysinghe, Manager Sustainable Tourism Unit SLTDA, Ms. Rajeeeka Ranathunga. Asst. Director STU and the Initiator of the Organisation Claude Gunasekera. Managing Director-StarMedia & Media Consultant HOT Tourism (Pvt) Ltd, Marketing Consultant 7Degree Immersive Restaurant, Colombo 5. Were present at the meeting.

Lanka Federation of Sustainable Tourism, launched recently with unwavering backing, and complete assistance with the endorsement of Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) the primary tourism arm of the government. The maiden preliminary meeting was held at the SLTDA Board Room presided by Upali Rathnayake, SLTDA's Deputy Director General and Head of Sustainable Tourism with key Tourism Industry professionals. Sri Lanka does not have a single "exclusive association" for sustainable tourism, but rather a multi-stakeholder approach led by the SLTDA and its Sustainable Tourism Unit (STU). The SLTDA works with the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) to implement the National Sustainable Tourism Certification (NSTC) scheme, partnering with international bodies like the Global Sustainable Tourism Council (GSTC) to foster sustainable practices across the industry, which recognizes tourism businesses committed to environmental, social, and economic sustainability.





OVERALL OBJECTIVE:

To establish a nationally recognized federation that unites diverse tourism stakeholders to collectively support promoting sustainable tourism practices in Sri Lanka through collaboration, knowledge sharing, advocacy, and supporting for innovation.

SPECIFIC OBJECTIVES

Create a unified body representing Government, International Organisations related to Tourism, Local Businesses (e.g. Hotels, DMCs, Local Tours Operators, Homestays etc.) engaged in Tourism and Supply chain related to Tourism Industry, Academic Institutions, Media, Civil Societies and communities involved in sustainable tourism.

Influence Policy and Governance:

Advocate for policies, incentives, and regulatory frameworks that foster sustainable tourism growth.

Advance Sustainable Practices:

Support to promote global sustainability standards and best practices across Sri Lanka's tourism sector.

Enhance Capacities:

Support strengthening the technical and practical knowledge of stakeholders through trainings, certifications, and hands-on tools for sustainable tourism.

Boost National Branding:

Support positioning Sri Lanka as a leading sustainable tourism destination through collaborative marketing and promotion.

Foster Innovation and Research:

Encourage data-driven decisions through research, case studies, and practical pilots.

Build Global Partnerships:

Connect with international sustainable tourism networks to bring global recognition and resources.

PURPOSE OF THE ASSOCIATION:

Serve as a catalyst for transitioning Sri Lanka's tourism sector into a **green, inclusive, resilient, and sustainable industry**. **Strengthen the institutional ecosystem around sustainable tourism** by filling the coordination gap between grassroots implementation and national policy. **Act as a knowledge hub for sustainability** in tourism, **Mobilize collective action** and support investment towards SDG-aligned tourism development, **programs and technical workshops** for members,

Code of Practice or charter adopted by members. Lobbying for industry challenges particularly in sustainable tourism, Support capacity-building Support creating a national Sustainable Tourism. Organise an Annual **Sustainability Tourism Forum** and **Awards Presentation Ceremony** for innovations and excellence in sustainable tourism in collaboration with SLTDA.

Coordinate to maintain media tools in **print, electronic and digital platforms/social media portals** for featuring resources, verified operators, events & activities to provide day to day information to members and tourists promoting sustainable tourism.

Sign **National and international MOUs** with Government Institutions / SLTDA, GSTC, UN Tourism, EU projects, and any other local and international party for uplifting sustainable tourism in Sri Lanka. Active participation in **Policy Development Forums** and working groups for the development of sustainable tourism, Support for national **marketing campaigns** and destination branding related to sustainable tourism.

MEMBERSHIP CATEGORIES AND CRITERION FOR ENROLMENT

Lanka Federation of Sustainable Tourism will introduce the following membership categories;

- STRATEGIC PARTNERS
- ADVISORY COMMITTEE
- ACTIVE MEMBERSHIP
- ASSOCIATE MEMBERSHIP
- AFFILIATE MEMBERSHIP

Strategic Partners:

Government Entities (e.g., SLTDA, DWC, CEA, Provincial Councils), Development Partners (UNDP, ADB, EU, GIZ, GSTC etc.), Financial Institutions and Individual Impact Investors....

Advisory Committee of 21 members from among the following entities;

- The Sri Lanka Government. (Minister, Deputy Minister or Secretary to the Ministry in charge of Tourism will be offered the honorary position of **Patron** by constitution).
- Chairman of Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority or by his nomination the Director General or Head of Sustainable Tourism of SLTDA will be offered the honorary position of **Deputy Patron** to act as a supporting role to the Patron.

Committee

- Political & State Sector Leaders,
- Academic & Professional Experts,
- Private Sector Hospitality Industry and Leaders in Sustainability, Biodiversity, Climate Change, in Hospitality Industry / Tourism.
- NGOs and INGOs supporting tourism sustainability
- Academic and Research Institutions
- Media, Advertising, Communication, Public Relations & Marketing Organisations.
- Tourism Consultancy Institutions

Advisory Committee members will elect a Chairman for the advisory committee who will perform the lead role in advisory decision making with consensus of the committee under the guidance of the Patron and Deputy Patron. ("With consensus" means reaching a state of general agreement within the committee, where a decision

or opinion is formed through discussion and mutual understanding, with the goal of a solution acceptable to all members, rather than through majority vote or forced compliance.



They will enjoy the full rights and Privileges of the association while they have full access to the decision making authority including eligibility to be elected for the Governing Board especially the posts of President, Secretary and Treasurer.

This category is considered as the CORE MEMBERSHIP of the Association.

To eligible for this membership they should be a;

Certified sustainable tourism player in the Sri Lankan tourism industry (defined as one that has been awarded certificate from a recognised institution for sustainable tourism practices accredited to the **Global Sustainable Tourism Council (GSTC)**, including but not confined to <https://www.gstc.org> or any other recognised certification awarding body such as;

▪ National Sustainable Tourism Certification (NSTC):

In Sri Lanka, the NSTC is an internationally recognized certification rewarding businesses for biodiversity conservation and sustainable practices, developed by the Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority and UNDP – (United Nations Development Programme). [<https://www.undp.org> › [srilanka](https://www.srilanka.gov.lk) | [<https://www.slttda.gov.lk>],

Green Destinations

[<https://www.greendestinations.org/awards-program>]





Associate Member

They will have the eligibility to be elected for Executive Committee (EXCO) except for key positions of President, Secretary and Treasurer. In essence, associate membership is a second layer next in line to be an Active Member after obtaining the Sustainable Tourism Certification. Sustainable tourism practicing players (uncertified), strives to balance the needs of tourists, the environment, and local communities, ensuring that tourism benefits all stakeholders while minimizing negative impacts and promoting long-term sustainability. Organisations engaged in this practice and those in the process of certification are eligible for Associate Membership Category.

Affiliate Member

Those organizations not coming under the category of Active membership or Associate Membership however who could support the association's goals including but not confined to NGOs and INGOs supporting tourism sustainability. Academic and Research Institutions, Media, Advertising & Public Relations Institutions, Tourism Consultancy Institutions.

Executive Committee:

Comprising representatives from Public and Private sector, Community Based Organisations and Academia.

Regional Chapters:

For provincial outreach and local coordination.

Sustainability Model:

Membership fees (for Corporates & SMEs), Development Grants, Donor Partnerships and CSR Contributions, Public-Private Funding for specific programs, Income from consultancy, research, and certification training services.

Proposed Governance Structure:

Executive Committee will be elected from among Active Members)



**Tourism Members
attended the
preliminary meeting
at the SLTDA**



Sri Lankan Tourism Development Authority (SLTDA) is pleased to announce the active operation of Sustainability Tourism Unit, aimed at supporting sustainable practices in Sri Lanka's tourism sector. The unit, established with the support of the United Nations Development Programme (UNDP) in Sri Lanka through the Biodiversity Finance Initiative (BIOFIN), to promote sustainable practices throughout Sri Lanka.
Contact SLTDA | Sustainable Tourism Unit (STU) Tel. 0112426800
Self-dial Ext. 171, 172 or <infonstc@srilanka.travel>.
Also visit www.sltlda.gov.lk/en/sustainable-tourism

Cinnamon appoints new Leadership Team



Ceremony held at Cinnamon Grand Colombo

Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts announced the new beginning of its leadership team assuming duties in new management



Kamal Munasinghe

Kamal Munasinghe has been appointed as the Chief Operating Officer of Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts the hospitality arm of the Sri Lanka's largest business conglomerate John Keells Holdings. He was functioning as the Vice President of Cinnamon Colombo Hotels and General Manager of Cinnamon Grand Colombo. **Nazoomi Azhar** was appointed as the new General Manager, Cinnamon Grand Colombo from the position of General Manager Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo. **Dushyantha Tittawella** appointed as the General Manager, Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo who was performing as Hotel Manager at Cinnamon Grand Colombo.

Veteran hotelier and industry powerhouse **Kamal Munasinghe** joined Cinnamon Grand and Cinnamon Lakeside in 2021 as General Manager to achieve a focused task of striving service excellence. He developed a professional hospitality workforce to deliver a memorable experience for guests in order to make Sri Lanka as a key travel destination. It was his choice to enhance the offerings of the Cinnamon Colombo Hotels and strengthen their position in the industry and better align the properties to cater to modern travellers. Munasinghe's new appointment proves the point of achieving the task of service excellence in Cinnamon Colombo Hotels. He brings nearly three decades of international and local hospitality expertise in managing luxury hotel brands such as Marriott, Hyatt and Mövenpick, including several local hotels that includes Mount

Lavinia Hotel, Kingsbury, etc. Munasinghe joined the Cinnamon Hotels from Alila Bangsar Kuala Lumpur (a Hyatt Hotels Corporation property). Both Cinnamon Grand Colombo and Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo are considered to be two of Sri Lanka's premier five-star hotels, with the two properties combined featuring the largest variety of restaurants that Colombo has to offer. Munasinghe is a hospitality graduate of Schiller International University, Switzerland and has been an excellent performer in the industry with career placements in Switzerland, Malaysia, Vietnam and Sri Lanka.



Nazoomi Azhar

Nazoomi Azhar is an experienced hospitality professional with over 25 years of experience, including significant work in the UK's hotel sector at Grange Hotels. He is an expert in strategic planning, operations management, and guest satisfaction. He serves Cinnamon hotels since December 2023. He holds an MBA from the European University of Business and a Bachelor of Business Administration from the International University of America.

Dushyantha Tittawella is described as a trained sommelier and experienced hotelier, bringing a strong background in wine and management to the role. His expertise in wine pairing and management is well-regarded. He holds an MBA from the University of Gloucestershire, UK.



Dushyantha Tittawella

Earlier, **Thushara Bandara** took up new role as Hotel Manager at Cinnamon Lakeside from the position of Director Food & Beverages at Lakeside. Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts also announced earlier a series of senior leadership transitions across its Sri Lankan resort portfolio, reflecting the Group's strategic commitment to strengthening internal talent pipelines, advancing inclusive leadership, and driving operational excellence across its Sri Lanka Resort portfolio.



Thushara Bandara

Cinnamon
HOTELS & RESORTS

Hishan Singhawansa

Murfad and Lankesha as Area General Managers



Hishan Singhawansa assumed duties as the new Chief Executive Officer, of Cinnamon Hotels & Resorts recently. His vision will be to strengthen the corporate role as a major contributor to Sri Lanka's tourism sector and position Sri Lanka as a globally recognized destination.

He joined the John Keells Group as a BPO for Resort Hotel Chain, then as a Management Trainee in 2008, Asst Manager in 2009, Manager in 2011 and took up overall responsibility of all supply chain activities of the "Keells Super" retail supermarket chain in 2012 held the position of Assistant Vice President (AVP) in 2014 and Vice President - Head of Supply Chain in results and mastery of duties time to time, joining as a BPO and rising up to the position of a VP within 7 years at a well reputed conglomerate in the country.

In 2017 he moved to the Resorts Sector, Leisure Group of JKH as Vice President / Sector Head and in 2018 became the Executive Vice President. He was appointed as Deputy CEO & Chief Operating Officer in 2020 and for 5 last years he had performed extremely well in this position until he was appointed as CEO recently.



Murad



Lankesha

Murfad Shariff has been appointed Area General Manager – Central and Eastern Resorts, Sri Lanka, overseeing Cinnamon Lodge Habarana, Habarana Village by Cinnamon, Trinco Blu by Cinnamon, Cinnamon Citadel Kandy, and the newly opened Kandy Myst by Cinnamon. With nearly 30 years of distinguished experience in the hospitality industry working in Sri Lanka and abroad, Murfad is known for people-focused leadership and a strong sustainability record. An alumnus of Trinity College, Kandy and an Associate Member of the SLHGA, he led Cinnamon Citadel Kandy to win SATA and Chairman's Awards in 2017 and contributed to national sustainability accolades in 2023 and 2024. His appointment ensures values-driven leadership and continuity across Cinnamon Sri Lanka Resort portfolio.

Simultaneously, **Lankesha**

Ponnamperuma has been appointed as Area General Manager – Southern Coast Resorts, Sri Lanka, overseeing operations at Cinnamon Bey Beruwala, Hikka Tranz by Cinnamon, and Cinnamon Wild. With over 15 years of executive experience in international hospitality, he is recognized for driving exceptional guest satisfaction, financial performance, and effective multi-property operations. Lankesha holds a Master of Business in International Hotel Management from the University of Queensland, a bachelor's from the University of Maryland Eastern Shore, and a Diploma from the Ceylon Hotel School. An alumnus of Trinity College, Kandy, his global perspective and operational expertise continue to strengthen Cinnamon's leadership across its beach resort portfolio.

Other reports from late July and August 2025 show the company also celebrated a "Leader of the Quarter" and recognized new team members and culinary achievements.

Thanuja Mudiyansele, became the Resort Manager at Trinco Blu by Cinnamon.

Fowme Ibrahim was appointed Resort Manager of Habarana Village by Cinnamon. **Charith**

Goonasekara joined Cinnamon Citadel Kandy as the new Resort Manager. **Keerthi**

Wimalasuriya moved to the southern coast to serve as Resort Manager at Cinnamon Bey Beruwala.

Other Celebrations and Announcements

Associate Quarterly Meeting (AQM)

at Cinnamon Lakeside Colombo celebrated achievements and exceptional individuals in late August 2025. Leader of the Quarter was **Rajitha**

Fernando, Director of Revenue & Cost Control, Finance, was recognized for his strong leadership.

Best Wishes

The **TOURGUIDE Editorial team** along with the publishers **H.O.T. Tourism (Pvt) Ltd.** and the Production House **StarMedia** together with the editorial Team of **NewsLanka** and **Lankapuvath** Congratulates the new Leadership Team. "We wish you all the best as you embark on this new chapter".



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SLITHM Launches Hotel Operations

MULTI-TASKER PROGRAMME

The Sri Lanka Institute of Tourism & Hotel Management (SLITHM), in collaboration with the Department of Sri Lanka Samurdhi Development, launched the "Sathkaraye Shrama Sena – Hotel Operations Multitasker Program" on September 3, at the SLITHM Colombo. This pioneering initiative is built on a strong Public-Private Partnership (PPP) model, bringing together the expertise of government institutions, private training providers, and industry stakeholders. The program is specially designed to develop the essential skills of the younger generation, preparing them as multi-skilled professionals to serve the fast-growing SME establishments in Sri Lanka's tourism and hospitality sector. Currently, 35 franchise institutes covering all districts have joined hands with SLITHM under this program, ensuring wide access to training opportunities for youth across the country. The national initiative, ceremoniously inaugurated at the Sri Lanka Institute of Tourism and Hotel Management (SLITHM) auditorium in Colombo.

Foreign Affairs, Foreign Employment and Tourism Ministry Secretary Aruni Ranaraja emphasised the programme's alignment with the government's economic vision.

"This programme is a critical investment in our country's future. It not only provides essential human resources for our vital tourism sector but also serves as a powerful tool for social upliftment by creating sustainable employment opportunities," she remarked.

Ranaraja emphasised that the financial backing from the Samurdhi Department is pivotal to the programme's mission of empowering the unemployed youth.

"The programme is a keystone of Sri Lanka's strategy to expand its tourism workforce to 800,000 by 2030, a necessary step to support the national target of attracting five million tourists and generating US \$ 10 billion in annual revenue by the same year" said Dheera Hettiarachchi Chairman SLITHM. He said the programme aims to train and certify 20,000 young individuals per annum, bridging a critical skill gap to meet the nation's ambitious tourism goals. He also noted that the industry currently employs approximately 421,000 directly and indirectly. "This PPP model, a first of its kind for a nationally recognised NVQ Level 3 course, allows us to leverage the island wide network of 35 partner institutions to scale up training and ensure the quality standards are met." Hettiarachchi said. Through this initiative, SLITHM and the Department of Samurdhi Development reaffirm their commitment to advancing Sri Lanka's tourism industry, while also creating sustainable employment opportunities and empowering the nation's youth.

Key Highlights of the Program were;

- Public-Private Partnership model – combining government support with private sector innovation to maximize reach and quality.
- NVQ Level 3 Certification – nationally recognized qualification upon successful completion. On-the-job training opportunities. direct exposure to industry practices.



Aruni Ranaraja

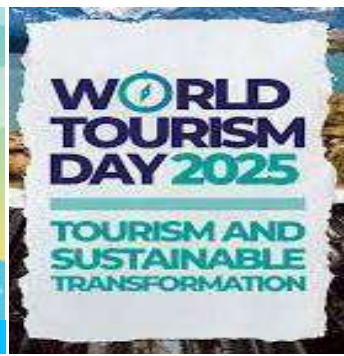
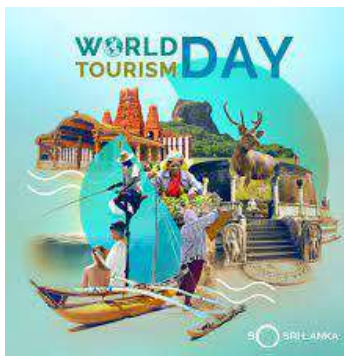


Dheera Hettiarachchi

- Nationwide promotion campaign – to encourage youth participation and awareness.
- Official Launching Ceremony** The Hotel Operations Multitasker programme is designed to equip youth with a versatile skill set covering front office operations, housekeeping and food and beverage services, culminating in a nationally and internationally recognised NVQ Level 3 certification. The programme structure integrates theoretical knowledge with crucial on-the-job training, ensuring the graduates are work-ready and can seamlessly integrate into the fast-growing small and medium-sized enterprise segment of the hospitality industry. The SLITHM will act as the chief franchisor, providing a training of trainers programme to its partners, to maintain a uniform, high-quality curriculum nationwide.



Sri Lanka's tourism target for 2030 is to attract 5 million visitors and generate \$8.5 to \$10 billion in revenue, **tourism workforce to 800,000** focusing on enhancing the quality of the tourism experience and long-term sustainability, rather than solely on increasing arrival numbers. This new vision emphasizes developing MICE Tourism and leisure travel, increasing the average daily spend per tourist, and fostering a more inclusive and globally competitive tourism sector.



"TOURISM AND SUSTAINABLE TRANSFORMATION"

UN World Tourism Day 2025 Saturday, September 27

World Tourism Day in 2025 will be celebrated on Saturday, September 27, with official celebrations around the world. The theme for this year is "Tourism and Sustainable Transformation" highlighting tourism's pivotal role in addressing climate change and driving socio-economic progress, with a special focus on "Rethinking and Reinventing" the sector for a more resilient and inclusive future. World Tourism Day 2025, theme is annually proposed by United Nations. This theme also emphasizes tourism's role as a catalyst for positive change, focusing on building a creative, innovative, and sustainable future through strategic planning and inclusive decision-making that prioritize resilience and social equity. Key aspects of this theme includes **SUSTAINABILITY**: Protecting the environment, using resources responsibly, and adopting sustainable lifestyles.

Transformation: Recognizing tourism's potential to drive social progress, deliver education, and create employment opportunities.

Innovation: Seeking creative and innovative approaches to overcome challenges like climate change and over tourism. **Inclusivity**: Deliberately integrating sustainability and social equity into the core of tourism development and decision-making. UN World Tourism Day of September 27 was chosen to mark the anniversary of the adoption of the Statutes of the World Tourism Organization (UNWTO) in 1970, a significant milestone in global tourism. World Tourism Day is an United Nations World Tourism annual international observance of the Organization (now UN Tourism) to promote public awareness of tourism's multifaceted importance.

Sustainable Transformation is the theme emphasizes the need to transform tourism to be more sustainable, innovative, and inclusive. It

underscores how tourism can be a catalyst for economic growth, cultural preservation, and environmental protection for Global Impact. The day focuses on how tourism can contribute to the education and empowerment of local communities and foster deeper cultural understanding for Inclusion and Empowerment.

Sri Lanka's Youth at the Forefront for Sustainable Tourism Transformation Sep 27 – Oct 1

Sri Lanka will commemorate UN World Tourism Day 2025 with the launch of a landmark nationwide hospitality skills development programme designed for secondary school students.

Spearheaded by the Alumni Association of Tourism Economics and Hospitality Management (AATEHM) of the University of Colombo and the Sri Lanka Institute of Tourism and Hotel Management (SLITHM), the initiative is endorsed by the Ministry of Education and the Ministry of Tourism. Introduced under the national theme "Tourism and Sustainable Transformation", the programme aims to create vocational awareness, instill sustainable practices, and expose students to professional hospitality standards. Open to students from Grade 9 upwards, it represents a bold step in preparing youth with the skills, values, and mindsets required to play an active role in shaping Sri Lanka's tourism economy. The initiative unfolds in two stages. In September, provincial competitions will

UN WORLD TOURISM DAY

27
SEP



take place across all nine provinces at SLITHM regional centers and partner hotels. Winners from these rounds will advance to a series of national-level events in Colombo that spotlight the country's commitment to youth empowerment and sustainable tourism.

The celebrations begin on 27 September with the Colombo Travel Mart 2025 at One Galle Face, where 75 stalls will bring together tour operators, travel agents, hoteliers, and international buyers. On 28 September, the focus will shift to the Sri Lanka Tourism Job Fair & Career Expo, organised by AATEHM and the Sustainable Tourism Unit with the support of SLTDA, SLAITO, SLITHM, and the University of Colombo. This will connect students, job seekers, and professionals with employers and training institutions, providing career pathways in tourism and hospitality.

On 30 September, the spotlight turns to the nation's youth with the Final School Tourism Club Competition, showcasing the talents and knowledge of students who have emerged from provincial rounds.

The programme will culminate on 1 October at BMICH, where multiple headline events will take place: the 10th International Tourism Research Conference, the 10th International Tourism Leaders' Summit, the launch of the Ruhunu Ring, the Vision-2-Voice Edition, and the grand award ceremony. This finale will bring together global and local leaders, scholars, and innovators to share insights on policy, sustainability, and future-focused transformation.

Beyond these milestones, the initiative builds more than technical hospitality training. It emphasizes essential soft skills such as communication, teamwork, adaptability, and problem-solving. By embedding sustainability into the competition framework, it encourages participants to consider the environmental, social, and cultural dimensions of tourism while gaining real-world experience. Together, these efforts ensure that Sri Lanka's next generation emerges not only with practical expertise but also with the responsibility and vision needed to lead the tourism industry into the future.

Lanka Alliance of Tourism Journalists



Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau intends to establish an Alliance for Tourism / Travel Journalists in Sri Lanka.

Mr. Sampath Nissanka, Managing Director of SLTPB will take the lead role in the forefront of the Alliance, while Ms. Sureshini Ellepola will coordinate all functions on behalf of SLTPB as her official role as Asst. Director (Local Media). Ms. Madubhani Perera, Director Media will also assist the endeavor. Claude Gunasekera, senior journalist, Chief Editor Lankapuvath / Newslanka and TOURGUIDE magazine has been assigned to organise the external part of the effort.

MD/SLTPB said "Travel writers have a dual impact: they positively promote destinations, boost economies, and foster cultural understanding, while also negatively contributing to mass tourism, potentially ignoring social issues, perpetuating stereotypes, and creating idealized, sometimes inaccurate, views of places. The way travel information is reported influences public perception, shapes visitor expectations, and affects tourism-dependent economies and local communities". He said travel writing attracts visitors, which can stimulate local economies, create jobs, and support infrastructure development and by sharing proactive experiences, writers can bridge cultural divides, promote understanding, and encourage a deeper appreciation of different ways of life.

Nissanka also noted that travel writers provide valuable information, allowing potential tourists to make informed decisions about destinations, activities, and potential risks. Highlighting about sustainable tourism practices, he said well-written travel stories can promote responsible tourism, highlighting efforts for sustainability and encouraging positive social and environmental change and adds Value to the Tourism Industry. Positive travel stories will help build destination brands and create imagination around places, influencing visitors' expectations and future travel decisions.

He also commented about the negative impacts contributing to Mass Tourism:

"An overemphasis on exotic or popular destinations can contribute to unsustainable mass tourism, putting pressure on local resources and the environment.

Exclusive Alliance for Travel Journalists

Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau actively works with travel industry professionals, including journalists, to promote sustainable tourism. SLTPB recently partnered with the British Guild of Travel Writers (BGTW) for a media convention in May 2025, aiming to boost the UK travel market for Sri Lanka. SLTPB also focuses on a broad range of tourism stakeholders, the relationship with travel writers is a strategic collaboration to share the nation's story and attract visitors,

Writers can amplify existing societal stereotypes or create new ones about destinations and their people, leading to misrepresentation. Travel writers have been criticized for focusing only on the positive or escapist aspects of a destination, failing to address or report on its social, economic, or political problems. Travel journalism often presents a positive and idealized view of destinations, which can set up travelers for disappointment when their reality doesn't match the narrative. A focus on certain destinations can lead to an uneven distribution of tourism benefits, potentially overwhelming local communities and infrastructure".

In conclusion of emphasizing these factors Sampath Nissanka said "Positive support from media persons is crucial for Sri Lanka's rapidly growing tourism sector because they can authentically showcase the island's diverse attractions, inspire global audiences, and counter negative perceptions, ultimately driving more tourist arrivals and contributing to economic growth. Through collaborations with Sri Lanka Tourism, media and influencers act as ambassadors, promoting authentic experiences and fostering a global understanding of the country's unique qualities and resilience.

Media professionals and travel bloggers can share authentic stories and experiences of Sri Lanka, creating a compelling narrative for potential tourists. He also noted that by partnering with Sri Lanka Tourism, media outlets and influencers reach large global audiences, amplifying the country's destination presence and promoting its cultural heritage and

diverse landscapes. Media plays a role in promoting the brand "Sri

Lanka," embodying the country's vibrant qualities and inspiring pride and a continuous effort for improvement among locals and visitors alike.

Sri Lanka Tourism leverages digital marketing and influencer initiatives to connect with modern travelers, especially younger demographics seeking authentic, sustainable, and diverse travel experiences.

In the wake of challenges, positive media coverage helps to build confidence in the country's recovery, reinforcing its status as a safe and attractive destination.

Sri Lanka Tourism hosts media and bloggers on familiarization tours to experience and cover various attractions and cultural events, generating positive and informative content.

The Tourism Promotion Bureau focuses on content-driven digital marketing, using social media and other platforms to share immersive content and engage with travelers. The selection of social media influencers who align with the destination's themes helps to truly showcase Sri Lanka's unique offerings to the global audience.

Nissanka finally pointed out "Therefore it is part of our duty to collaborate with the media professionals both local and overseas as Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau (SLTPB) is responsible for marketing and promoting Sri Lanka as an attractive destination, highlighting the nation's natural beauty, cultural heritage, and adventure experiences. The SLTPB conducts promotional campaigns in key international markets, provides information to tourists through its information centers, and **works to develop a sustainable tourism product.**

Any media professional / Journalist particularly engaged in Tourism/Travel Journalism is eligible to join the Lanka Travel Journalists Alliance.

The Alliance offers two types of membership as ACTIVE MEMBER and ASSOCIATE MEMBERSHIP. Tourism Journalists serve in the capacity as; Correspondents, Reporters, Sub Editors, Editors, Media / Content Creators, Travel Influencers or Bloggers, Photo Journalists, Photographers, Videographers attached to Print, Radio, Television, Online, or Digital platforms are welcome to enroll as an Active Member.

The ASSOCIATE MEMBERSHIP is open to PR Agency Representatives, Destination Marketing Professionals or Hospitality Industry Marketing/Communications/Public Relations professionals.

The Alliance will be an organization focused on promoting professional and ethical practices among travel writers, photographers, and publicists based in Sri Lanka.

The Alliance connects public relations professionals with travel media offering, networking events and tools to promote tourism. Access to a community of peers and industry contacts.

The Alliance will support members to have Professional Development such as; Opportunities for learning through webinars, workshops, and industry events. Facilitate Mentorship and Professional Guidance through opportunities with experienced industry professionals both Story Ideas, Assignments and opportunities that can lead to paid assignments.

Code of Ethics: Members are typically required to agree to and uphold a professional code of ethics.

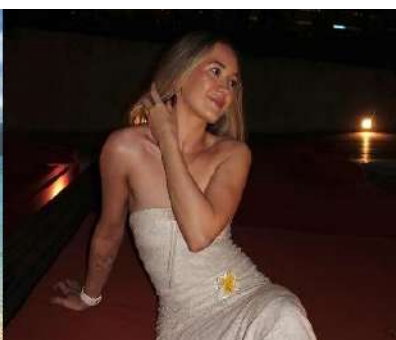


Australian Influencers to Showcase Sri Lanka's Wonders to Millions Worldwide

As part of a renewed effort to position Sri Lanka as a top long-haul destination for Australian travelers, the Sri Lanka Tourism Promotion Bureau (SLTPB) organised a special influencer familiarization tour featuring four prominent Australian social media personalities. The group arrived and explore the island end August. This promotional initiative formed part of SLTPB's ongoing global digital outreach strategy aimed at attracting high-yield tourists through content-driven marketing. During their nearly two-week visit, the influencers experienced a carefully curated selection of attractions, from cultural landmarks such as Sigiriya, the Dambulla Cave Temple, and the Temple of the Tooth Relic, to natural and wildlife highlights including the Ella train ride, Yala National Park, coastal gems like Pasikuda Beach and Galle Fort, and modern developments such as Port City Colombo and the Lotus Tower. The itinerary blends heritage, wildlife, beach, and urban experiences, ensuring each facet of Sri Lanka's tourism appeal is authentically showcased.

The visiting influencer group includes Sheridyn Fisher, a lifestyle and wellness creator with 491,000 followers on Instagram and 3.4 million followers on Facebook, known for promoting mindful living and elegant travel storytelling. Ashley Parker, a highly followed TikTok personality with 2.5 million followers and 138,000 on Instagram, brings a high-energy, adventure-driven narrative to her global audience. Cerys Lily, who transitioned from a nursing career to travel content creation, boasts over 215,000 followers on TikTok and 38,500 on Instagram and is admired for her honest and relatable travel experiences. Ella DelNore, a rising figure among digital nomads, has nearly 200,000 TikTok followers and 25,300 Instagram followers, offering a unique lens focused on remote work, wellness, and eco-tourism. The campaign is expected to generate wide-scale visibility for Sri Lanka through real-time video content, cinematic reels, personal reflections, and curated photo stories shared across Instagram, TikTok, Facebook, and YouTube. These digital activations are projected to reach a global audience of over 200 million through combined

impressions, significantly enhancing Sri Lanka's destination presence in the Australian market. Officials from Sri Lanka Tourism emphasized that the influencer initiative is a targeted marketing effort to reach younger, experience-driven travelers who seek authenticity, diversity, and sustainability in their travel choices. The influencers, selected for their audience engagement and thematic alignment will serve as digital ambassadors who can authentically showcase the unique experiences Sri Lanka has to offer. With Australia recognized as a growing and valuable tourism source market for Sri Lanka, this campaign is poised to play a vital role in increasing inbound arrivals, particularly during the upcoming southern summer season. It also reinforces SLTPB's strategic pivot toward content-driven digital marketing, supporting the island's tourism recovery and growth on the global stage. This initiative builds on SLTPB's past influencer engagements and reflects a dynamic shift in how the Tourism Promotion Bureau connects with modern travelers through authentic storytelling, community engagement, and immersive digital content that inspires exploration.



Actively participate in Reshaping Tourism

for the better.

Based on the World Tourism Day theme for 2025 **"Tourism and Sustainable Transformation"** involves rethinking how tourism is developed and experienced to benefit communities and the environment for future generations. This means focusing on long-term goals, strategic planning, and inclusive decision-making that prioritizes sustainability, resilience, and social equity to transform the tourism sector into a force for positive change.

Go beyond simple growth and integrate long-term sustainability goals into every aspect of tourism planning and development. Prioritize Community Engagement, ensuring that tourism development benefits local communities by supporting local businesses, artisans, and providing equitable economic opportunities.

Protect Natural Ecosystems by focusing on conserving natural resources and regenerating marine ecosystems to ensure that future generations can also enjoy them.

Implement deliberate and inclusive governance frameworks that place social equity and resilience at the core of tourism decision-making.

Engage youth in the sustainable tourism movement through education and hands-on experiences to build a more sustainable future for the sector, as seen in initiatives like scheduled 2025 World Tourism Day Programme from September 27 – October 1 in Colombo.

Encourage travelers to engage with local communities responsibly and support efforts to protect the environment. "Tourism and Sustainable Transformation" calls us to action:

It's an invitation to Government, Tourism Businesses, and **especially Travelers** to actively participate in reshaping tourism for the better.

Tourism can be a powerful tool for social progress, delivering education, employment, and new opportunities when managed sustainably. It emphasizes meeting the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.



Priantha Fernando

Advisor LANKATOURGUIDE Magazine

Former Chairman of (SLTDA)

Sri Lanka Tourism Development Authority



SUSTAINABLE SRI LANKA

Inviting you to achieve uniqueness of Tourism Industry by advertising in an exclusive sustainable tourism news & features portal in Sri Lanka – the print and online magazine focused on authentic, narrative-driven content that highlights the country's cultural and natural experiences of local communities and entrepreneurs, demonstrating how travel directly contributes to conservation and well-being, rather than simply listing attractions.

We provide storytelling to connect with local and international travelers' desire for mindful, impactful experiences and to differentiate Sri Lanka from competitors by showcasing its unique eco-initiatives. We also feature stories from local communities and entrepreneurs involved in sustainable tourism, showcasing their transformative experiences and contributions to the industry. We also go beyond visuals to multisensory branding: highlighting the sounds, tastes, and unique "feel" of Sri Lanka's natural and cultural environments, which fosters a stronger connection with potential visitors.

We present tangible examples of how travelers can make a positive impact.

One of our main purpose is to promote the National Sustainable Tourism Certification (NSTC) to build credibility and demonstrate Sri Lanka's commitment to sustainable practices, attracting conscious travelers. We support the hospitality industry in Sri Lanka to connect with Global Goals, thereby, frame sustainability efforts in the context of larger, universal goals, such as contributing to the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs). While promoting wildlife and nature we focus on the "responsible and meaningful encounters" with wildlife and the educational aspects of these experiences. We use vivid imagery and descriptions to showcase the diversity of Sri Lanka, from pristine beaches to lush mountains and unique ecosystems, as a way to offer "un-missable experiences".

We invite tourism industry partners to join hands with this mission through your advertising support in order to continue this important national effort successfully.

ADVERTISING RATES

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Full Page Colour – Inside Page	: (LKR) Rs. 25,000.00
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Quarter Page is 35% of Full Page	– Only Inside Pages

Advertisement for 3 months contract – 30%

Advertisement for 2 months contract – 15%

Please note advertising rates will be revised in December 2025

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